

Using Herbal Remedies Safely

One reason that herbal remedies are so popular is that plant medicines are safer and cause fewer side effects than conventional ones. However, herbal remedies are not always safe, and—like medicines of every kind—they need to be used with care.

What Can Go Wrong?

Following a few simple rules will normally ensure that the worst that happens when taking an herbal medicine is that there is no improvement in your condition. Nevertheless, there are situations in which herbal remedies can cause damage, and several medicinal herbs have been shown to interact with conventional medicines. In very rare circumstances people have become seriously ill or have died from taking herbal medicines, though in almost every case the problem has resulted from one of the following safety factors being ignored. If at any time you think that you are reacting badly to an herbal medicine, stop taking it immediately, and contact a qualified herbalist or naturopath, or your doctor.

How Problems Can Occur

The wrong herb is used due to mistaken identification. Usually, when herbs are bought over the counter you have no need to worry, as the necessary checks have been made to ensure it has been correctly identified. If you are harvesting

herbs from the wild, you must be certain what herb it is that you are collecting. For example, ragwort (*Senecio jacobaea*), which is very toxic to the liver, can easily be mistaken for St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106): both grow in open areas and produce clusters of bright yellow flowers in the summer. In rare cases, the physical act of picking certain highly toxic herbs could be dangerous, because absorption takes place across the skin. Hemlock (*Conium maculatum*, p. 194), for example, is so toxic that serious side effects can result from simply handling the plant.

The wrong part of an herb is used. It is important to use the correct part of the herb. Sometimes one part of a plant is safe, while all other parts are poisonous. For example, while the potato tuber (*Solanum tuberosum*, p. 271) makes good, nutritious food, all other parts of the plant are highly toxic.

Poor-quality material is used or the herb has been poorly prepared. If you are making up your own remedy, follow the recommended methods for storage and preparation (see *Harvesting & Processing*, pp. 288–289). If buying over the counter, check the section on *Quality Control* (see p. 17) for advice on purchasing good-quality products.

The wrong herbal remedy is being used. You can avoid this problem if you stick to using well-known herbs and take them to treat the conditions for which they are usually recommended. Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155) and sweet flag (*Acorus calamus*, p. 57) both help to relieve nausea and indigestion, but ginger is an altogether safer medicine—it is better known, is a common treatment for motion and morning sickness, and, unlike sweet flag, has no known side effects.

The herbal remedy interacts with other medicines. Herbal remedies are medicines, so it should come as no surprise that conventional medicines can interact with them. Several herbs are known to interact with conventional medicines. St. John's wort, for example, speeds up the rate at which the liver breaks down a range of drugs, including certain antibiotics, antiepileptics, and immune-suppressants. This reduces their



Dong quai has been shown to thin the blood and is known to interact with conventional anticoagulants such as warfarin.

effectiveness within the body, and in extreme situations could threaten life. It is also inadvisable to take St. John's wort at the same time as other antidepressants. A number of herbs, notably dong quai (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63), interact with anticoagulant drugs, such as warfarin and clopidogrel. These drugs are prescribed to prevent blood clotting. Herbal products containing these herbs will interact with anticoagulants and increase the risk of internal or external bleeding. Always tell health-care professionals what medicines you are using—both herbal and conventional. If you are taking medicines prescribed by your doctor, it is always sensible to seek advice before starting to take herbal remedies.

The herbal remedy causes an allergic reaction.

By and large, allergic reactions to herbs result from touching the herb (contact dermatitis) and from breathing in pollen or powdered herb (airborne allergies). Some plants are well known for causing contact dermatitis—rue (*Ruta graveolens*, p. 265) for example—and should not be handled by those prone to allergies. Some powdered herbs can stimulate sneezing attacks in the sensitive—for example linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277). In some cases, herbal medicines may trigger allergic reactions within the body. This kind of response is more worrying, and if you are prone to allergies it is advisable to see a qualified herbalist before taking all but the most common herbs.

Other treatment is needed. Sometimes herbal medicine is not the appropriate form of treatment. If you have an acute illness or injury, are seriously ill, or do not recover as expected after taking an herbal remedy, *do not delay*—seek professional advice or emergency treatment.



Ragwort is a toxic plant and, with its yellow flowers, easily mistaken for St. John's wort.